
Memorandum

THE ARLINGTON INSTITUTE [REDACTED]

To: Steven Greer
From: [REDACTED]
Date: 21 October 1993
Subject: Project Starlight

I very much appreciated our time together in Ft. Collins and am honored to have been taken into your confidence. I hope that I can be of some help to your most important endeavor. By the way, a copy of my report, *The Road to 2012*, has been sent to you separately.

I have given some thought to your upcoming project and offer the following:

Assumptions:

A CSETI press conference with former US government employees will be held to establish that the USG has been aware of and dealing with ETI for some time, and that the incidents of ETI contact have been increasing significantly in the recent past. This press conference will be held within eighteen months (probably in February) and may or may not have government support. If USG support is forthcoming, it may be at any of a number of levels varying from behind the scenes acquiescence to a jointly coordinated effort that includes a statement by the President changing the USG policy vis a vis ETI.

In anticipation of the press conference, CSETI has begun what is planned to be a series of confidential briefings for selected leaders of different sectors of the society. If government cooperation is obtained, these briefings may include international sessions including some with foreign heads of state.

CSETI sees this event and its associated briefings as setting the stage for the initial formal contact between humans and ETI, which is likely to transpire within 36 months.

From CSETI's point of view, the objective – the output – of this project is:

[Steven, can you articulate this clearly and succinctly]

CONSIDERATIONS:

- ♦ *This is probably the most important thing that anyone dealing with this project — from the President on down — has ever done in his or her life. The implications and potential fallout from this event have profound importance for the future of human life on earth. The project demands extraordinary effort and calls for unequalled diligence.*
- ♦ *It is important that you do not lose control of the process, either to the USG or to other groups or individuals. When it begins to take off, there will be unbelievable pressures that will, if they are given in to and not anticipated, fragment and capture the message. The most powerful people in the world will use every resource available to them to attempt to accomplish their personal objectives relative to this matter — what ever those objectives happen to be.*
- ♦ *This is a big — a huge — deal that will require involving a significant number of very good people (the absolute best that you can find) to bring their expertise to bear in carrying out what needs to be done. A small core group of professionals will need to be engaged to help think through the process: legal, marketing, public relations, etc. You cannot afford to make mistakes that are obvious to those who understand well those areas into which you must venture. I can help you with some of these folks.*
- ♦ *Additionally, you will need a couple or three close confidants who are your strategists and message-minders. It will be increasingly hard for you personally to maintain an arms-length, objective relationship to what is going on as the tempo increases. You need wise counselors who are knowledgeable about every aspect of the process and have your confidence.*
- ♦ *A serious attempt must be made to think through and identify every potential track that this process might take, therefore making it possible to plan for those contingencies. You must not be blindsided.*
- ♦ *You must not think too small. Most of the approaches and techniques that we are familiar with work for much smaller issues than what is being contemplated here. This is a global issue and we must not either get too fixated on either the US or approaches that are comfortable and obvious. Some new ground will have to be plowed. We will have to invent some of this.*
- ♦ *You cannot just take this up through the press conference . . . and attempt to walk away to pursue the formal contact phase. That would be like throwing warm meat to a pack of starving dogs. This project must include planning for the post-conference period — probably at least six months. This whole beginning of this transition to this new era must be carefully orchestrated.*
- ♦ *This could be overtly used to bring rogue countries back into the fold. The correct overtures to Syria, Libya, North Korea, Iraq, Burma, and Iran could have profound implications on the future of global geopolitics.*

THE MESSAGE

1. The most important aspect of this project is the positioning of the message.

How the message that is delivered at the briefings and press conference is designed and characterized will have everything to do with its success. If it is positioned incorrectly, it will immediately produce negative images in the minds of some of the audience -- images that will be very hard, if not impossible, to change.

Industrial societies (and I suspect lesser developed societies as well [I can find out]) have three general psychological groups within them: *inner-directed*, *outer-directed*, and *sustenance-driven*.

The inner-directed look within themselves for direction; they march to the beat of their own drummer and start all major social trends. They respond to *personal growth and altruism*.

Outer-directed individuals look outside themselves for their sense of meaning and sense of accomplishment. Life is a ladder to be climbed and one's position on the ladder, indicated by brands, activities and reactions by "important" people is what life is about. This group drives fads and fashion (short-term trends.) They respond to *power*.

Sustenance-driven people are risk- and change-adverse. They are driven by the need for security. They are followers who are the last to change and will change only when threatened. They respond to *fear*.

These three orientations exist in all of us, but in most cases, one is dominant. They are psychological characteristics independent of income, education and social status -- there will be a broad cross section of people within each category.

The message must be structured so that it is positioned for each of: personal growth/altruism, power, and fear. It must have three facets that nest cleanly with these three areas of motivation.

Everyone must hear his or her own message, and that message must clearly encourage movement toward our objective and set up blocks against alternative interpretations.

2. The message must be easy to understand and unambiguous.

The ideas must telegraph immediately and should probably be couched in terms of images that parallel human life, e.g. visiting a foreign country and meeting new friends, etc. Historical mistakes, such as our past dealings with native Americans, should perhaps be remembered to the audience.

3. *There must be high levels of quality control to protect the integrity of the message.*

It is important, to the extent that it can be influenced, that the content of the message remains the same as it is passed deeper and deeper into the society. To that end, you should consider producing a video cassette that contains the "official" message. Perhaps this could be coordinated with the White House and include a message from the President. A way of producing mass quantities of them and distributing them very rapidly should be investigated.

If it was possible to pull it off, you might consider doing some focus groups to probe likely responses to the final message. They could probably be cast as investigations into reactions to possible endings for a new Spielberg movie.

The media will play a pivotal role in this regard. A section of this memo therefore deals specifically with media affairs.

THE STRATEGY

This project should be the subject of at least one three-day strategic planning workshop. The key participants should be brought together to go over and think through every possible aspect of how this should be executed. This is important not only for logistical but for team-building reasons.

Some initial considerations:

1. The process must be executed quickly

Time is the enemy. You must assume that because of the immense interest in this subject, people will find it hard to not talk about what they have heard from the briefings. If you are giving regular briefings, it will only be matter of time (7-14 days) before the whole process takes on a life of its own. You will be able to get heads of state and Kissinger-like folks to keep quiet, but at some point someone will pull the plug out of the dam and the whole thing will cascade. Therefore, this phase must be very carefully scheduled and efficiently executed.

My guess is that at the beginning (for the first 10 days), you can do one or two briefings a day with very high level people. The last three or four days would be a crash of five briefings per day culminating with the press conference. The Congress and the press should be near the end of the process. Anything printed that you pass out will very quickly be copied and distributed, regardless of whether the recipients say they won't or not.

2. Understand the dynamics of this process

We should find a good social psychologist to help us think through the strategy, presentation, etc. There are probably a couple of dissertations out there about how new information travels through the social groups, and at least one academic who could be helpful.

3. Get government help

If the government gets on board, Dave Gergen could provide valuable input to the strategy design process. He has a very acute and accurate sense about how to do things like this.

THE BRIEFINGS

1. Communicate highest level of seriousness

It is important that the briefings communicate the highest level of importance (and significance) to those who attend. It would be helpful to have a little cover in the briefings (which will happen before your press conference and the eyewitness testimony) that establishes your bona fides with the US intelligence and policy communities. To that end, it would be good if you could get the CIA to give you a knowledgeable guy to come to each major briefing and say, "I have clearance from the highest authority to support this endeavor and tell you that the U.S. government believes that the time has come for a change in policy regarding ETI." (I may be able to help you do that through a meeting with Jim Woolsey -- but ultimately you would need the President's commitment.) Perhaps the USG would provide some declassified pictures that you could show -- but not give -- to the briefees.

We must develop a brief, but clear image of the worst case situation (if the message gets out of hand) and find the appropriate way to communicate it easily so that recipients understand what is at stake here.

2. Briefing sequence

You must first target the opinion leaders and then work down from there. The objective is to talk first to those whom others will want to listen to for advice. That means that a well thought out plan should be developed that, over a two-week period, will systematically saturate those that most influence the decisionmaking in this country. For the press, for example, it is not enough -- in one sense, not that important -- to brief the TV anchors, because it is the commentators -- the hired guns -- who will opine most about this event. We must identify the producers, reporters, commentators, anchors and network heads, and work them in the right sequence. It would be helpful to find a couple of producers that we could work with who would steer us to the appropriate commentators and resource people.

Similar strategies must be developed for other social segments -- government, academia, business, the general public, etc.

3. Keep quiet as long as possible

As long as possible, the participants should be asked to maintain this information in confidence. It will begin to leak before you get through all of the briefings (and perhaps give you an advantage in having peaked the interest of some of the downstream prospects), so the whole process should be orchestrated with that in mind. I know some people who, at the right time, could be brought in to help on thinking about this.

4. Protect the press conference

You should think about whether the briefees should be told about the coming press conference. It might be better for them not to know it is coming (and therefore not be encouraged to upstage the President, etc.)

5. Post-conference briefings

There will be a post-press conference requirement (after you have stirred up the hornet's nest) for a flurry of additional briefings. Newspaper editorial boards, Larry King, etc. will demand additional information. [By the way, you will essentially be out of the trauma medicine business forever starting about a month before the press conference.] You should use some time between now and the press conference to think through what that message will be and anticipate how you can use the high level of interest to provide the sustenance for your efforts up to and after the time of format contact.

THE MEDIA

The media must be understood for who they are -- the deliverers of your message. As such your precious communication is completely in their hands. They can deliver it accurately or not -- you have no control over them. The best message in the world is valueless if miscommunicated, therefore considerable thought must be given to how to deal with the press.

1. A media strategy

We must think through how the different communications media, ranging all of the way from word of mouth to television, should be used to promulgate this message. As best we can, we must try to be there first with the information and images rather than having people find out about this from second- and third-hand sources.

Television is most important. The news programs, daytime talk shows (Opra, Donohue, etc.), issues shows (Meet the Press, McLaughlin, etc.), CNN, and all other important outlets must be carefully woven together into a scheme that reaches out and envelopes the globe.

We also must think about how to use CNN, Star TV and other international outlets to reach the rest of the world during and after the press conference.

Perhaps we could get a station to run the briefing video every hour on the hour for two or three days. The video should be dubbed in a half-dozen languages and made available to the international press.

2. The press is in the business of not keeping a secret

Keep in mind that all of the motivation and incentives for the press is to tell a secret first. Therefore, you should understand that when you brief them (even on deep background), it will only be a matter of time before they find a way to get their people working on this "biggest story in history."

3. Give them a lot of information

Most journalists will use what they are given. Therefore, every attempt should be made to answer every significant question and provide as much back-up information as possible before

the fact. We must to our best to upstage the "UFO ghetto" by providing far better and more credible information than any other source. We must establish CSETI as the primary, if not sole, source for info on this trend.

4. Managing the media process

You will absolutely need a media coordinator and small staff to provide a point of contact for the media. They will do anything they can to get interviews and information; the crush will be immense and someone experienced should be responsible for it or you will alienate the press and force them to look elsewhere for information (because they have deadlines). You might be able to hire this service.

5. Treat them all the same

In general, you should establish some rules that would tend to provide equitable access to all legitimate press. We must not make them angry. The combination of anger, and fear or apprehension (from the significance of this issue) could produce very unfavorable results. They are all competing with each other and must think they are all being treated fairly.

THE BRIEFING LIST

[I have included some names where I know them. All of the right people can be identified.]

The Press

Print Publishers & Editors

U.S. News & World Report

Newsweek

TIME

The New York Times

The Washington Post

The Boston Globe

The Chicago Tribune

The Los Angeles Times

The Philadelphia Inquirer

The Dallas Morning Herald

The Christian Science Monitor

The Wall Street Journal

Major Foreign Press Reps in Washington

Selected Columnists

William Raspberry - The Washington Post

Anthony Lewis - The New York Times

Anna Quinlan -

[there are about a half dozen others here]

Television Network and News Heads

CNN
CSPAN
ABC
NBC
CBS
Turner Broadcasting
Fox Broadcasting

Wire Services

UPI
AP
Reuters

Personalities

Opra Winfrey
Phil Donohue
Ted Koppel
Dan Rather
Peter Jennings
John McLaughlin
John Chancellor
David Brinkley
Geraldo Rivera
Rush Limbaugh
Paul Harvey
Robert McNeil
James Lerher
Bernard (CNN anchor)

Regular Program Participants on:

Meet the Press
Face the Nation
The McLaughlin Group (Mort Kondracke, Fred Barnes, Eleanor Cliff, Jack Germond)
Washington Week in Review
McNeil/Lerher News Hour
The Capital Gang (Michael Kinsley/Pat Buchanan/John Sununu/Robert Novak)

Commentators/Resource People

MG Perry Smith - CNN Military correspondent
LTG Bernard Trainor - Security Studies Program, Kennedy School, Harvard

The Internet and other Computer Networks

These entries into international cyberspace reach deeply into academia and other communities and perhaps are now second only to the press in general importance and ability to reach thinking people.

Electronic Freedom Foundation (Mitch Kapor/John Perry Barlow)
The Well - Howard Rheingold, Peter Schwartz, Stewart Brand
CompuServe
Delphi Network
Prodigy
America Online
Usenet (interest group heads)

Think Tanks

Brookings -
American Enterprise Institute
Center for Strategic and International Studies
The Heritage Foundation
The Cato Institute
Economic Strategy Institute -

Major Religious Groups

Evangelicals - *Christianity Today* - Publisher Harold Myra plus the editor, Philip Yancey
Billy Graham, Pat Robertson,
Mainline Protestant - *The Christian Century* - Publisher & Editor, James Wall
Catholics - Joseph Cardinal Bernadin - Chicago
The Pope

The Military

Chairman and Vice Chairman, Joint Chiefs of Staff
Secretaries and Undersecretaries of Services
Service Chiefs and Vice Chiefs
Secretary of Defense, Deputy Secretary of Defense, Under Secretary (Policy),
Asst. Sec. (Strategy/Policy)

State Department

Secretary of State, Deputy Secretary of State, head of diplomacy area.

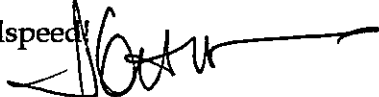
White House

National Security Council: Anthony Lake, Sandy Berger, Robert Bell
David Gergen, George Stephanopoulos, Mack McLarty

OTHER THOUGHTS

1. I hope that you are keeping a good journal. There's an extraordinary book, film, television series, etc. here. Also the history of this process should be documented.
2. This project should have a code name. You will find it valuable to be able to refer to this in a shortened/cryptic form in a number of situations. My contribution: **Project Starlight**
3. You should start thinking now about, and perhaps start putting things in place for, the follow-up to the formal contact. Think of this thing as a package -- a whole -- and design this project to cleanly interface with the formal contact . . . and the follow-up to that. Think about what you want in the end and then work backward through these events, structuring them so that they are synergetic.
4. You should consider whether you want to use this extraordinary exposure to build a funding base for CSETI. There are thousands if not millions of people who would love to give five or ten dollars to help assure this transition to a new era goes well. You should never, ever ask for money, but you will constantly be asked in interviews about how CSETI is funded, and that could present a particularly good opportunity for a low-key comment about "some individuals think it is important that this be done right and choose to help us."
5. Although I dislike doing this, for lack of a better device I am sending along a copy of my resume. It will give you a bit of an idea of who I have been.
6. I will provide any help to this project that I can and you desire.
7. I will send a clean copy of this to you in the mail.
8. We return from China late at night on 8 November. I have kept open most all of the 9th for you (I have an 8:00-9:30 a.m. meeting.) If you want me to meet you somewhere, send me a fax [keep in mind that others may read it before I do] and I'll pick it up that evening. You're welcome to come by here -- whatever is convenient. I'll pick you up at the airport if you'd like. Just let me know.

Godspeed!

A handwritten signature in black ink, appearing to be 'G. S. S.', written over a vertical line that extends from the 'Godspeed!' text.